Q+A

Drawing the Human Condition

With *In Another Mode: Sudhir Patwardhan's Drawings 1970–2000*, the artist reflects on 30 years of his relationship with Mumbai and the role of the human figure in his work

Q. Your drawings often focus on the human figure. What were you looking for in the figure at that stage?

In the mid-1970s, on suburban trains, I would sit opposite people and imagine what kind of life they had and what tensions were expressed through their physique and body. I would try to imagine those tensions in terms of my own body. I was discovering the pressure points of a body trying to remain whole, with different forces working against each other.

Q. Did drawing serve a different function for you from painting?

Yes. Drawing is related to thinking and visual strength. You see a person bending in a certain way and make a notation. It may enter a painting ten years later, or never. You made the notation because you found that moment interesting. Drawing can also be more psychological, something you need to get out of your system.





Q. How did your relationship with Mumbai change over the years?

In the 1970s and 1980s, one identified with the city and felt, "This is my city, this is where I belong." After the 1990s, particularly after the Babri Masjid demolition, that sense became fragmented. There was a turning inwards, towards family space and interiors. One's relationship with the city became problematic.

Q. Looking back, do you see yourself as the same artist?

I feel somewhat distanced. Is it the same person who was 20 and the same person at 70? If I connect with who I was at 20, it is through memory. In that sense, they are different people, living through different situations and different periods of the city.

—with Nikhil Sardana

The show is on display at Vadehra Art Gallery till Oct. 23

Photograph by RAJWANT RAWAT